

Yom Kippur 5784

We are constantly making sure that we do things correctly. However, to do things לפנינו משורת הדין, for example, to be מוותר, requires an extra-special effort. It is that kind of behavior that will stand us in good stead for the upcoming יום כיפור. If we go out of our way to be מוותר, to give in, to say to the other person “You’re right” even if we think that they might not be right, that will stand us in very good stead. The following story illustrates this in a powerful way.

A new sefer came out which retells stories, which you may or may not want to believe, about people who have פגישות with נשמות in the next world. The book is called, ‘Regards from Our Upstairs Neighbors’. Here’s the story.

It was said of a certain famous politician that you can know when he’s telling a lie: If his lips are moving, you know he’s lying. The following story may sound weird or unrealistic. I get that. It really does sound improbable, but I also know this fellow, let’s call him Yaakov. He is the polar opposite of the opening joke. If his lips are moving, you know he’s telling the truth. I’ve had the pleasure of working with Yaakov in a number of business deals. He’s a highly respected businessman and upright and down-to-earth guy, definitely not the someone-came-to-me-in-a-dream type. When Yaakov’s mother passed away, she left a terrible void. In her will she instructed her two children, “Please, divide all my possessions in half. There should always be shalom between you.” Her possessions included a number of estates. However, Yaakov’s sibling lived in one of them. The property was actually legally under Yaakov’s name, and therefore he felt that this particular estate was not among the possessions that were meant to be divided.

At first, Yaakov wanted to contest the will, or at least suggest that he receive a similar share in one of the other properties instead. But then he recalled his mother’s plea for shalom, and realizing that this could easily escalate into a full-blown fight, he courageously decided to remain silent and swallow the loss. Their attention then turned to the other properties. Yaakov’s sibling asked to buy out the remaining estates for their then market value, which happened to be at an all-time low due to a dip in the market. Once again, Yaakov remained silent. Even after the meager property value was calculated, Yaakov only received his share over a course of several years in five-hundred-dollar increments which disappeared as quickly as they came. In the meantime, the original property’s market value soared. Yaakov felt that he had received virtually nothing, but once again, he did not say a word.



At one point, Yaakov's sibling called him, unaware of his feelings. "Look, the money I owe to you is more or less paid up," the sibling said. "Let's calculate it and see if I still owe you anything." The calculation of the total value from the various slips of paper revealed that after all was said and done, Yaakov had been overpaid, and now he owed his sibling some seven thousand dollars. To be clear, this sibling is a wonderful and giving person. It was Yaakov who went out of his way to avoid confrontation. Yaakov's impulse was to say, "Oh, okay, I'll pay it in tiny installments," but once again he caught himself and said nothing.

With a big smile on his face, he wrote out a check for the full amount and handed it over to his sibling. The accounts were finally completely settled and the story was over. Or so he thought. A few seconds later, Yaakov's breath nearly caught in his throat. Before him, standing and smiling joyfully, was his deceased mother. She looked at him with soft eyes and just smiled as if to say, you have made me so happy, my son. Then she disappeared. Sharing this story with me, Yaakov told me with emotion, "I saw her vividly and clearly. I was not hallucinating. She was right there before me." Stopping thoughtfully for a moment, he continued, "Believe me, everything was worth it to see her like that."

We want to get through **יום כיפור בשלום**. We want to see our children, **אייניקלאך**, and our whole family well. In the **זכות** of **תשובה תפילה וצדקה**, may we have a **גמר חתימה טובה** and **גוט געבענטשט געזונט יאר**.

